



△ One of the malachite stones featuring carvings of classical scenes

Queen Desideria's malachite parure

Unlike many treasures held by Europe's royal families, the 19th-century parure owned by Queen Desideria of Sweden and Norway is made from something quite common – an inexpensive green stone called malachite.

Despite its lowly status as a gemstone, malachite became the height of fashion in the early 1800s, due in part to the era's obsession with new geological discoveries. It was often set into jewellery, and was even used to inlay entire rooms. Malachite is not transparent and is not cut into facets like diamonds; rather, it is formed into smooth cabochons or carved into detailed shapes.

Queen Desideria's parure is something of a mystery. Although it appears on an official list of the queen's jewels, there is no record of her wearing it. There are some clues, however, as to its origin. The back of the tiara bears the initials "SP" and the French assay mark 1819–39, almost certainly indicating it was made by high-society Parisian jeweller Simon Petiteau,



Malachite Hall, Winter Palace, St Petersburg, Russia, designed in the 1830s by the architect Alexander Briullov and named after its malachite columns and fireplaces

probably during the 1820s and 1830s when the queen was living in Paris. Decades earlier, Désirée Clary – as she was known – the daughter of a wealthy French merchant, was engaged to Napoleon Bonaparte, who abruptly left her to wed Josephine de Beauharnais. Two years later, Désirée married General Jean-Baptiste Bernadotte, who, possibly at Napoleon's suggestion, was elected Crown Prince of Sweden. While Bernadotte spent much of his career on military campaigns, the queen lived

mostly in Paris, where she is thought to have acquired the parure. Adding to the intrigue, Napoleon's wife Josephine also owned a malachite parure set with carved cameos.

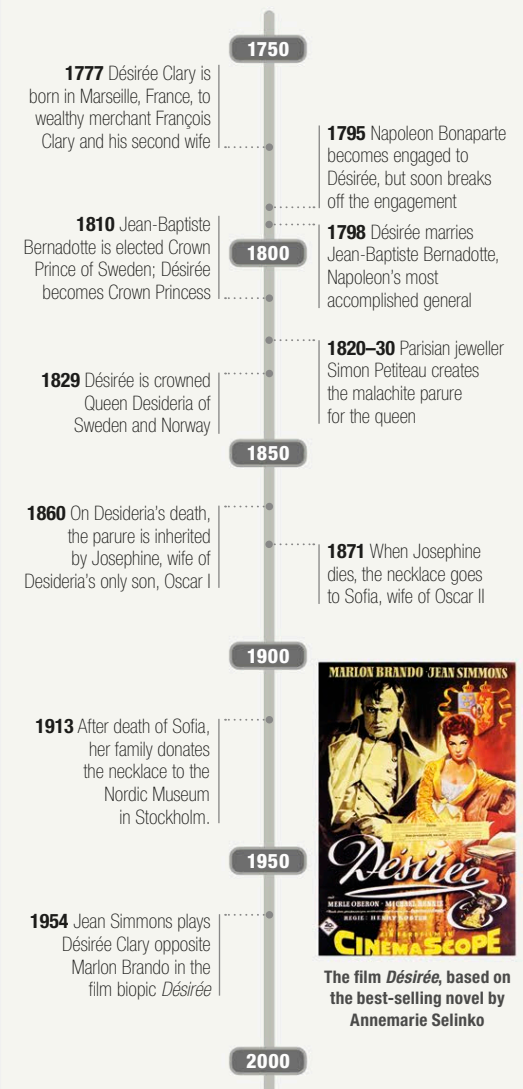


Malachite carvings set in gold

Queen Desideria's parure, with malachite carvings featuring classical scenes from antiquity

Key dates

1777–1954



The film *Désirée*, based on the best-selling novel by Annemarie Selinko

It was my destiny to be attractive to heroes

Queen **Desideria**